legislators, especially from ethnic parties. Through them, they learned how the Hluttaw works, as explained by the Kayin legislator Mahn Aung Tin Myint:

> I am not in the peace committee and I don't know why. But I was able to explain our parliamentary experiences to my old colleagues [EAG members] when they visited Naypyitaw during the national census launching ceremony. The relationship between us [ethnic legislators] and ethic armed group members is tricky. We know each other very well but we have to play safe because we can breach the Unlawful Associations Act.[10]

The Hluttaw tried to use all available options to accommodate half-century long borderland conflicts and to get involved in the peace process. Conventional tools such as consultations among stakeholders, executive oversight, promulgation of laws, and budget scrutiny were used. Lawmakers were able to show themselves as role models, engaging in a rule-based forum where conflicts are institutionalized. Questions and motions were again used extensively to express the concerns of the legislature. But, as mentioned above, the role of the legislature was more of a legitimizing and supporting role than a mediating one.

Communal violence

While Myanmar was praised for its peaceful transition, it was disrupted by the communal violence in Rakhine State and subsequent violence across Myanmar from 2012 to 2014, which was regarded as a significant shift, if not setback in Myanmar's transition (ICG 2013). Sparked by a rape and murders in June 2012, it quickly escalated into a widespread communal conflict between Rakhine and Muslims (Bengali/Rohingya).[11] According to the Rakhine State government estimates, 192 people died and 6,614 homes were destroyed in eleven of the state's eighteen townships in 2012 alone (Rakhine Inquiry Commission 2012, p. 31). The violence was followed by numerous outbreaks of communal clashes in various parts of Myanmar, most notably in Meiktila where forty-four people were killed and 1,818 homes destroyed (Pyidaungsu Hluttaw 2013).

Unlike in the peace process, the role of the Hluttaw in tackling communal conflict was quite modest. The Hluttaw did not denounce these conflicts nor urge the government to take prompt actions. There were no formal consultations between Rakhine and Muslim legislators, nor with